



The Best Places to Eat Kaiseki

Kikunoi expensive

Kyoto's finest *kaiseki* restaurants can be rather daunting, impenetrable places – some shun diners they don't know – but there are a few that welcome *kaiseki* novices, offering proper seats instead of a *tatami* mat and explaining the courses to their guests. Of these, the most renowned is Kikunoi ("chrysanthemum well"), awarded three Michelin stars in 2011. It was founded in 1912 and is run by the third-generation chef Yoshihiro Murata in a historic *ryotei* surrounded by immaculate Zen gardens, home to the freshwater spring from which the restaurant gets its name. Courses during a *kaiseki* could include raw baby squid marinated in soy, exquisite sashimi, sumptuous monkfish liver, and, unusually for a *kaiseki*, duck and beef from Hyogo Prefecture's Wagyu cattle. Clients argue over the best time of year to visit – given the seasonal nature of the food – but fall is probably the most compelling season to dine at Kikunoi. Many of the world's greatest chefs have made a pilgrimage here.

459 Shimokawara-cho, Higashiyama-ku, Kyoto;
open noon–2 PM and 5–8 PM (last entry) daily;
www.kikunoi.jp

Also in Kyoto

Kaiseki comes in many forms. Its most perfectly realized expression is usually found in *ryotei*, but the term is just as often used to describe any vaguely traditional, multi-course Japanese meal served *omakase* (orchestrated by the chef). Kikunoi (*above*) has a less formal sister restaurant, **Roan Kikunoi** (www.kikunoi.jp; *moderate*), but for a more contemporary yet still authentically Kyoto-style *kaiseki* in a restaurant, try **Aunbo** (+81 525 2900; *moderate*), in the atmospheric Gion district. The meticulously crafted, super-fresh ingredients used by chef Tashima in his cuisine will include tofu, local *kyo-yasai* (Kyoto vegetables), and fish, which you can enjoy while gazing thoughtfully at the restaurant's equally immaculate Zen garden.

Also in Japan

One restaurant that has picked up a great deal of buzz – along with two Michelin stars – in recent years is **Ryugin** (www.nihonryori-ryugin.com; *expensive*) in Tokyo. In this tiny, ornate, windowless dining room in a back street of Roppongi, chef Seiji Yamamoto creates gorgeously elaborate, multi-course meals from super-fresh, seasonal Japanese ingredients.

Around the World

Kaiseki has been hugely influential on the multi-course, fixed menu style of *haute cuisine* dining that has spread throughout the top restaurants of Europe and America. You can see echoes of *kaiseki* in the elaborate cuisine of restaurants such as **The Fat Duck** (www.thefatduck.co.uk; *expensive*) in the UK and Copenhagen's **Noma** (www.noma.dk).